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The Unspeakable in Cornelius Eady's *Brutal Imagination*

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In her "Unspeakable Things Unspoken," Toni Morrison develops the "unspeakable" while critiquing the U.S. American literary canon's Whiteness – or, more directly, White U.S. American authors' marginalization and exclusion of Blackness in the U.S. literary canon – arguing that "Canon building is empire building" (8). In her lecture-turned-essay, race itself is the "unspeakable thing," in particular how racial matters remain silenced due to the sociopolitical climate and racial anxieties resulting from the collective traumas of slavery and its afterlives, and the "unspoken" signifies how Blackness haunts U.S. American literature and society – the proverbial "ghost in the machine" (8). One of Morrison's chief tactics for speaking the unspeakable in her own literary work is her employment of the nonhuman to identify and challenge the ontological violence upon which the U.S. master narrative's curation of Blackness is built. It's the Whiteness in *Song of Solomon* (1977) that is representative of the overwhelming and oppressive brutality of White supremacy – the white bull; the white peacock; the divinity candy, traditionally white, that turned Guitar to anything sweet for how it reminds him of his mother's pandering performance after the White sawmill owner responsible for his father's death gives her $40 dollars as compensation. It's Claudia's blue-eyed baby doll and the Shirley Temple cup that symbolize internalized racism in *The Bluest Eye* (1970). It's the personification of 124 to demonstrate the breadth and continuity of U.S. slavery's hauntings and Mister the Rooster who is offered a dignity that is denied Paul D in *Beloved* (1987). And still more. Morrison (re)codifies these objects and figures such that they function metaphorically to illuminate aspects of the anti-Black climate that surrounds us – what Dr. Christina Sharpe theorizes in *In the Wake: On Blackness and Being* (2016) as "the weather" – and problematize and complicate U.S. American literature and culture's limited and limiting framing of Blackness, while contemporaneously calling out the construction of Whiteness as the privileged, "natural" state that too often operates under a cloak of invisibility.

The exploration of the nonhuman is familiar within the study of Black literature and culture. In *Habeas Viscus: Racializing Assemblages, Biopolitics, and Black Feminist Theories of the Human* (2014), Alexander G. Weheliye

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observes that if we understand race as "a conglomerate of sociopolitical relations that discipline humanity into full humans, not- quite- humans, and nonhumans, then blackness designates a changing system of unequal power structures that apportion and delimit which humans can lay claim to full human status and which humans cannot" (3). Weheliye then expands on the work of Black feminists Hortense Spillers and Sylvia Wynter to argue that Black studies works to decolonize the category of human through its exploration of the nonhuman to critique what has been centered as physically, racially, and sexually normative – "human." Morrison's use of nonhuman images and figures plays on this criticism while employing the nonhuman as a sign of the physical and sexual violence visited upon Black bodies throughout the entirety of U.S. history as well as the social death associated with Black non/being. Further, it operates as rhetorical tactic that allows Morrison to engage with this same critique of the "human" through evoking what bell hooks calls the oppositional gaze, with the lens not resting voyeuristically on the gratuitous violence against Black bodies but on the inhumanity of a Whiteness that actively participates in and perpetuates a system where Paul D looks up to Mister.[1] Cornelius Eady mirrors this aspect of Morrison's writing in his 2001 poetry collection, *Brutal Imagination*. Much like Morrison's employment of the nonhuman, Eady's conjuring of a nonhuman persona facilitates an oppositional gaze focused on White supremacy and how its violences build from the ontological to the structural.

Placing Eady within Morrison's wake works in several respects. Eady is often noted, and rightly so, for his co-founding of Cave Canem with Toi Derricotte. Founded in 1996, Cave Canem has grown from a 26-poet workshop organized "to remedy the under-representation and isolation" of Black poets in the U.S. literary landscape to one of the most influential and potent institutions in U.S. American poetics, with its fellows going on to win many of the most prestigious awards in the poetry world ("Mission and History"). As such, it would be accurate to liken Eady to Morrison through their shared focus on increasing the volume – both audibility and quantity – of Black literary voices. That said, Eady accumulated the social capital needed to help establish Cave Canem and help build it into one of the most prominent forces in poetry through putting in poetic work. Before finishing his MFA at Warren Wilson, Eady had published *Kartunes* (1980), earned an NEA, and became the second Black poet to win a Lamont Poetry Prize (now the James Laughlin Award) for his second collection, *Victims of the Latest Dance Craze* (1986). His third collection, *The Gathering of My Name* (1991), was nominated for a Pulitzer and was followed by *You Don't Miss Your Water* (1995), *the autobiography of*

[1]In "Oppositional Gaze: The Black Spectator" from *Black Looks: Race and Representation* (2014), hooks describes how "all attempts to repress our/black peoples' right to gaze had produced in us an overwhelming longing to look, a rebellious desire, an oppositional gaze. By courageously looking, we defiantly declared: 'Not only will I stare. I want my look to change reality.' Even in the worse circumstances of domination, the ability to manipulate one's gaze in the face of structures of domination that would contain it, opens up the possibility of agency" (116).

a jukebox (1997), *Brutal Imagination* (2001), and *Hardheaded Weather: New and Selected* (2008). Eady has collaborated with jazz composer Deidre Murray to convert parts of his works into musical theater productions, including the second cycle of poems in *Brutal Imagination*, titled "Running Man," which was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize in Drama. In this regard, Eady might also be said to be following in Morrison's footsteps with his award-winning books and/or through their similar success in converting their literary works into theatrical productions. Yet, it's *Brutal Imagination*'s first cycle and namesake that is this article's primary focus for how it deploys Morrison's use of the nonhuman as a tactic for constructing a critical counter-narrative.

The poems in the collection's "Brutal Imagination" cycle portray the events that compose the Susan Smith case. In 1994, Susan Smith reported that a Black man wearing a knitted cap carjacked her at a secluded intersection with her children inside. There was a nationwide search with dozens, if not hundreds, of supposed sightings of the nondescript Black man flooding into police stations. Nine days later, Susan Smith confessed to drowning her own children, three-year-old Michael Daniel Smith and 14-month-old Alexander Tyler Smith, having strapped them into their car seats and letting her car roll into John D. Long Lake. Eady's interest in Smith originates from his curiosity in the mechanisms that allowed and inspired Smith to evoke the Black alibi, commenting that: "It's that agreed upon fantasy of thinking that we [Black men] are these violent, irrational monsters that would do stuff like this … Again, with *Brutal Imagination* the question for me was *Why was it so easy for her to do that? Why was it so easy?*" (Eady; emphasis mine). On the surface, Smith's act of filicide bears some similarity to Margaret Gardner's, which inspired Morrison's *Beloved*.[2] Though terrible, the unspeakable in *Beloved* is not Sethe's violence

[2]In the coda of the book manuscript I am completing, currently titled "Second Throat: 21st-Century Black U.S. American Historical Persona Poetry and the Archive," I argue that Morrison's *Beloved*, in particular, stands out as an important precursor the 21st-century Black U.S. American historical persona poetry trend through how it models fabulation as a tactic for staving off the historical erasure and negationism – empowered by racial resentment and anxieties – that drive past and current anti-CRT/anti-truth/anti-history movements. While Eady's *Brutal Imagination* is the focus of this article it is emblematic of a larger trend within 21st-century Black U.S. American poetry. In the introduction of "Second Throat" I write that:

> In a 2013 entry [titled "A List of Volumes Featuring Persona Poems (by Year)"] on his influential blog, *Cultural Front*, Howard Rambsy II lists recent volumes of Black U.S. American poetry that feature persona, positioning 20 collections that include some significant offering of persona poems in chronological order, starting with Tony Medina's *Sermons from the Smell of a Carcass Condemned To Begging* (1998) and ending with Frank X. Walker's *Turn Me Loose: The Unghosting of Medgar Evers* (2013). Rambsy II himself would likely admit that this list is only a beginning, with collections that have been featured or reviewed on *Cultural Front* not included – Marilyn Nelson's *Carver: A Life in Poems* (2001) and *A Wreath for Emmett Till* (2005), Kevin Young's *To Repel Ghosts* (2001) and *To Repel Ghosts: The Remix* (2005), Honorée Jeffers's *Outlandish Blues* (2003), and Elizabeth Alexander's *American Sublime* (2005), to name a handful. Further collections, like A. Van Jordan's *M-A-C-N-O-L-I-A* (2004), have yet to receive much space on *Cultural Front* and several more collections have been published since the list was constructed, such as Tyehimba Jess's Pulitzer-prize-winning *Olio* (2016). (1)
>
> Other collections that employ a nonhuman speaker(s) include Mariyln Nelson's *Sweethearts of Rhythm* (2009), which personifies musical instruments who speak nostalgically on the all-woman swing band, International Sweethearts of Rhythm. She also speaks through the voice of the tree from which Emmett Till was lynched in the third sonnet of *A Wreath for Emmett Till* (2005). Tyehimba Jess, for whom Nelson is a big influence, utilizes objects such as Leadbelly's gun, his guitar, a street, and a recording device to speak in *leadbelly* (2005). Also, the majority of Patricia Smith's *Blood Dazzler* (2008) is spoken through Hurricane Katrina.

against her own children, which echoes the Gardner narrative, but the circumstances – the physical, psychological, sexual, and other violences that were heaped upon the enslaved, including having one's "human characteristics" listed along with one's "animal ones" (Morrison, *Beloved* 228) – that brought Sethe to make such an awful decision in order to save her children from slavery. Similar to Sethe's story, what brings the Smith story into the unspeakable is not Smith's murder of her children – an act that was no doubt much less selfless than Sethe's – but her evocation of and participation in the systems that construct Eady's *Why*, the same ones that, through the ontological violence of the myth of Black criminality, feed and justify racial hoaxers like Smith and the state violence and racial terrorism that the hoaxers sic on Black(ened) peoples. As such, the cycle's primary speaker embodies Eady's quandary as the personification of this corner of what Morrison referred to as the "Africanist presence" as a means to underline and critique how Blackness is constructed in the White literary imagination, and in the broader racial imaginary, as "a fabricated brew of darkness, otherness, alarm, and desire" (Morrison, "Black Matter(s)" 147).

The "Brutal Imagination" cycle opens with "How I Got Born" and its epigraph, which introduces the cycle's primary speaker, later named Mr. Zero, as "the young black man Susan Smith claimed kidnapped her children" (5). Eady immediately complicates that seemingly simple sentence, revealing Mr. Zero's existence did not begin with Smith and proving the poem's title to be an intentional misnomer, a bit of ironic trickery:

> Though it's common belief
> That Susan Smith willed me alive
> At the moment
> Her babies sank into the lake
>
> When called, I come.
> My job is to get things done (5)

Mr. Zero is not born in Susan Smith's car, or even in her mind. He is merely "called," clocking in, and Smith just happens to be the one employing him in this instance. In a personal interview with Eady, he deconstructs Susan Smith's decision to claim a Black man stole her car and abducted her sons:

> In the Susan Smith story, there are two constructs. One is the invention of the African American villain, but she is also constructing a victim that looks like the imaginary guy. She wants the authorities to look for somebody who is the closest to her nightmare … The second construct got thwarted, thank God, but that's what she was doing. She was inventing a plausible villain, but she was also inventing a plausible victim, so that somebody gets on death row, because he fits the profile that she is constructing … We are lucky that it didn't work out that way, but that is what she was going for, and it has worked that way. (Personal Interview)

In addition to drawing the correlation between the plausible villain and plausible victim, Eady connects Mr. Zero to recent iterations of the Black brute trope, or what Katheryn Russell-Brown refers to as "the myth of the *criminalblackman*" (3) in her *The Color of Crime: Racial Hoaxes, White Fear, Black Protectionism, Police Harassment, and Other Macroaggressions* (1998). Like the Black brute, Russell-Brown's *criminalblackman* was formed from and broadcasted by the media's disproportionate and hyperbolized portrayals of Black deviance. This "entrapment by media imagery" has effectively fixed the association of Black men with crime in the racial imaginary and, furthermore, is evidence of representations of Black people as pathologically criminal which has operated as a means to execute and justify antiBlack agendas (Russell-Brown xiii). Further, Eady's personification of Mr. Zero more specifically links the nonhuman speaker to the long line of White women falsely accusing Black men and boys that runs from no doubt many unnamed enslaved and free Black men who were lynched because they fit the description of the plausible villain/victim, and includes Emmett Till and his accuser, Carolyn Bryant Donham; and the more recent Amanda Knox case and her lying on Patrick Lumumba, and so on seemingly ad infinitum.[3] Yet, Eady also ties Smith to Charles Stuart – a White man who shot and killed his pregnant wife and blamed it on a Black man in 1989 – in "Charles Stuart in the Hospital" (22). Thus, Eady's use of the nonhuman immediately engages the reader in the past and present of the myth *criminalblackman* as a racist idea that further propagates the ontological violence that Eady describes in the constructs of the plausible villain and plausible victim.[4]

The palatable Blackness of the plausible villain

After the first six lines problematize the notion that Smith *birthed* Mr. Zero, the next six lines of "How I Got Born" discuss Smith's particular evocation of Mr. Zero and individual need for the plausible villain. The lines read:

> I am piecemeal.
> I make my living by taking things.

[3]While this article was being written, news broke that a team including members of the Emmett Till Legacy Foundation as well as a members of Till's family found an unserved warrant charging Carolyn Bryant Donham – identified in the document as "Mrs. Roy Bryant," Roy Bryant having been her husband and one of the men who lynched Till – for the 1955 kidnapping of Till in the basement of a Mississippi courthouse.

[4]As Kendi puts it in *Stamped for the Beginning: The Definitive History of Racist Ideas* (2016), this is the mission behind racist ideas:

> The principal function of racist ideas in American history has been the suppression of resistance to racial discrimination and its resulting racial disparities. The beneficiaries of slavery, segregation, and mass incarceration have produced racist ideas of Black people being best suited for or deserving of the confines of slavery, segregation, or the jail cell. Consumers of these racist ideas have been led to believe there is something wrong with Black people, and not the policies that have enslaved, oppressed, and confined so many Black people. (10)

So now a mother needs me clothed
In hand-me-downs
And a knit cap. (5)

Here Mr. Zero describes Smith quilting him out of tropes she pulled from the racial imaginary. Smith's two requests for his uniform are signs of the pathological Blackness – "hand-me-downs" signaling a lower socioeconomic status and a "knit cap" pointing toward criminality. In her confession, Smith revealed that she planned to commit a murder-suicide but jumped out of the car at the last minute and ran with her hands over her ears so "she would not hear her sons cries or the car splashing into the lake" (Rekers 86). The *Washington Post* quoted an unidentified police source who recounted to *The Post* in 1994 that "Every part of [Smith's] world was falling apart, and one thing led to another … There doesn't seem to have been great plans aforethought in her actions. They just happened" (Iati). Yet, while the source's comments seem to imply the racialized description of her imagined carjacker to have "just happened," the history of racial hoaxes tells us differently. Instead, Smith's "piecemeal" (5) description in "How I Got Born" reflects the education described in the poem "My Face":

…when you were
Of a certain age
Someone pointed
A finger
In the wrong direction

And said:
All they do
Is fuck and drink
All they're good for
Ain't worth a shit. (10-11)

This is further evidenced when one considers how the sketch artist to whom Smith described her fictional perpetrator initially reported him wearing a baseball cap, then Smith switched it to a knit cap, seemingly as an attempt to further cement the figure's imagined Blackness.[5] Instead, Smith's imagined Black carjacker and kidnapper reveals Smith as literate enough in stereotypical imagery of Black people that she was able pull these tropes from out of thin air despite the immediate trauma of having just murdered her own children.

[5]The 1995 *New York Times* article "Sheriff says Prayer and a Lie Led Susan Smith to Confess" describes how Smith "'started out extremely vague,' said Roy Paschal, who helped Mrs. Smith with the composite drawing of the phantom suspect. She gave conflicting descriptions, saying once that the man had worn a baseball cap, then a knit cap" (Bragg).

A key rhetorical strategy of the dominant culture is the framing of racial hoaxers like Smith as wayward individuals not representative of the greater public. We see this strategy in other racialized phenomena as well – police officers and White supremacists who brutalize and kill BIPOCs, judges and prosecutors who have been found to have unjustly prosecuted and/or sentenced BIPOCs, politicians who push policy with racist outcomes who are outed for making their bigotry too visible or public, educators and educational administrators who champion racist curriculums and/or pedagogies who are caught being too openly racist in the classroom or on social media, and all the other ways in which the public finds it more comfortable to understand individuals as "bad apples" as opposed to seeing them as active agents of traditions supporting and supported by systemic racism. This is often done by othering the individuals and their actions through the use of ableist language like "crazy" and "insane." Smith does this herself in her confession, and her mental state was an integral part of her defense.[6] Twenty years after the murders, *The State* reporter Harrison Cahill reached out to Smith to get her take on how time has impacted her feelings about what she did. In her response, she explains to Cahill that "I was not in my right mind." She writes that "I am not the monster that society thinks I am," and "The only reason I lied is because I didn't know how to tell the people who loved Michael and Alex that they would never see them again" (qtd. in Cahill). Her letter makes it clear that Smith, even twenty years later, is concerned with describing her mental and emotional state at the time of the murders; however, she offers little in the way of explaining why she told the particular lie she told.

Ultimately, her lie demonstrates her clear understanding that, even in the moments immediately following her own murderous act, the fictional Black monster – the plausible villain – would give her story the highest degree of believability (and, in at least her opinion, would be the most palatable story for those who loved her sons). Further, her claims about her state of mind, however valid or invalid, operate as an attempt to distance herself from the culpability of the murders as well as from her racial hoaxing. Therí A. Pickens resists this tactic in her essay "Amy Cooper is Logical." In the essay, Pickens responds to a more recent racial hoax in which Amy Cooper – a White woman – attempted to weaponize her White license and the police against Christian Cooper – a Black birdwatcher of no relation – after he had

[6]In Smith's confession's opening sentence, she labels herself as "mentally distraught" before going on to discuss her anxiety and suicidal ideations and later describing herself as a "nervous wreck" (qtd. in Laboratory for Scientific Interrogation, Inc). George Rekers says of Smith's confession in *Susan Smith: Victim or Murderer* (1996) that "she wanted to appear as a helpless victim of mental illness…This turned out to be a cleverly pragmatic ploy by her defense attorneys to avoid the death penalty for her" (124). See also the Laboratory for Scientific Interrogation's analysis of Susan Smith's confession, and "Susan Smith's Handwritten Confession" on the website for *The Hoax Project* (managed by the University of Maryland's Philip Merrill College of Journalism) for a full transcript of the confession.

asked her to follow park rules and leash her dog. Pickens resists responses to the episode painting Amy Cooper as "crazy" as "not just a rhetorical move; it is part of a cultural end-game that creates safety for those who want to put rhetorical and psychological distance between themselves and Amy Cooper." "Crazy" functions as a tactic reducing the racial hoax to an act of interpersonal racism, while denying the systemic racism that is both the backbone and blood of the hoax. Framing the racial hoaxers, the Amy Coopers and Susan Smiths, "as individual actors, not part the American fabric" (Pickens) goes beyond color-evasive racism in its denial of the implicit and explicit bias that makes Black men low hanging fruit for the racial hoaxer and does not adequately implicate those who are all too eager to embrace the racial hoax. As George Rekers chronicles in *Susan Smith: Victim or Murderer* (1996), folks from Smith's husband, David Smith, to her lover, Tom Findlay, to folks working in or with the police department and media questioned Smith's affect, prioritization of Findlay, the details of and inconsistencies in her story from day one, yet that did not stop the incredibly expensive and extensive nine-day search.[7] Which is to say, when Susan Smith described a Black man to the police sketch artist, she was operating from, and speaking into, a clear logic. And that logic, despite the questionability of Smith's story, was readily embraced and imbibed on a national level.

Eady's use of the rhetorical and metaphoric potential of the nonhuman persona is particularly evident and effective in his pronoun play in the "Brutal Imagination" cycle. This is first signaled by the formal break that takes place between the penultimate and final stanzas of "How I Got Born." The first two stanzas are neat quatrains that run pretty congruently. They both feature a second line that rises out of a shorter first line before collapsing into a four-syllable third line from which the fourth line expands to match or exceed the length of the first two lines. Both stanzas also feature a Mr. Zero who uses first-person pronouns for himself and third-person for Smith that clearly distinguish Mr. Zero from Smith: "Though it's common belief/That **Susan Smith** willed **me** alive/At the moment/**Her** babies sank into the lake/When called, **I** come./**My** job is to get things done" (5; use of bold typeface is mine). The penultimate stanza is consistent in its point of view, yet the final line of its quatrain has been absorbed into the hinge that occurs at the beginning of the final stanza – "Whatever" (5) – inflating the final stanza to five lines, while also announcing the formal break that introduces the conflation of Smith and Mr. Zero into a collective "we": "We arrive, bereaved/On the stranger's step" (5). A superficial reading of this line might imagine Mr. Zero and Smith as separate entities grouped

[7]Some of these questions and concerns are summed up by the photographer at Smith's first newspaper interview the day after the murder when chatting afterward with the reporter who conducted the interview: "Why would a black man on the run want two screaming children in the backseat? And white children at that? Wouldn't that be awfully suspicious?" (Rekers 102).

together through the "we," but, as we know, Smith did not arrive on that "stranger's step" with a Black man in tow, or even an actual Black man in mind. This pronoun play continues in the *we*'s and *our*'s that are prominent in the first and third sections of the cycle as well as the final two lines of the poem that makes up the fourth and final section, "Birthing."

Reading "Who I Am?" through this lens helps to address and further complicate the poem's titular question and, moreover, to further illuminate the efficacy of Eady's use of pronouns and persona. In the poem, Eady imagines the scene in Smith's burgundy 1990 Mazda Protégé before she drowns Michael and Alex Smith. Mr. Zero is driving, and the boys are buckled into their seats, with the opening line attributed to one of boys who wonders: "*Who are you, mister?*" (7; italics present in original). The rest of the poem comes in the way of a response. Similar to "How I Got Born," the first two-thirds of the poem presents a clear distinction between Smith and Mr. Zero through Mr. Zero's use of first- and third-person pronouns that begin in the poem's fourth line: "If I am alive, then so, briefly, are they" (7). The "three and one" of the next line is a literal reference to Michael's and Alex's ages, but it also doubles as a sort of inventory of who is in the car – the three Smiths and Mr. Zero – all of them "Quiet and scared, bunched together/Breathing like small beasts" (7). Though the pronouns still indicate the bifurcation of Smith and Mr. Zero, the two start to merge as the poem progresses. Where before there was confusion about Mr. Zero's identity, now there is recognition:

> They can't place me, yet there's
> Something familiar.
> Though my skin and sex are different, maybe
> It's the way I drive
> Or occasionally glance back
> With concern, (7)

Mr. Zero is still different from Susan Smith here, but Mr. Zero is beyond "familiar;" particularly as he exhibits (presumably) Smith's maternal mannerisms. Eady is imagining the boys seeing their mother in Mr. Zero and Mr. Zero in their mother. The "mixed" in the following line carries weight in the meaning of the poem as it indicates the conflation of Smith and Mr. Zero. The pronouns mirror this through the switch from the "I/me" and "they" from before to the "us" and "we":

> Maybe it's the mixed blessing
> Someone, perhaps circumstance,
> Has given **us**,
> The secret thrill hiding,
> Childish, in plain sight,

Seen, but not seen,
As if suddenly given the power
To move through walls,
To know every secret without permission.
We roll sleepless through the dark streets, but inside
The cab is lit with brutal imagination. (7)

The pronoun play constructs a rich dualism. The persona "I" allows Mr. Zero to embody the immediate persona subject – in this case Smith's specific evocation of the *criminalblackman* – while also serving as a shorthand for a larger set of ideas. In this sense, Eady's use of persona in the "Brutal Imagination" cycle creates a space where Mr. Zero's "us" refers to both the trope as an individual occurrence as well as how the trope operates historically and contemporaneously in a society all too familiar with the Black-man-as-plausible-villain narrative. The persona "I" also enables the dualism between Smith and Mr. Zero. The conflation of Smith and Mr. Zero further demonstrates Mr. Zero as the personification of the Black trope of the *criminalblackman* on one level; however, on another deeper level he is also a part of Smith as a figment of the "brutal [White] imagination." The dualism fostered through the use of persona troubles the dominant culture's desire to write off Smith as operating out of her own individual dysfunction and instead exposes Smith as metonymic of a system of White supremacy that has constructed in its imagination the Black monster, the plausible villain, as well as what all that has been done in the name of Whiteness to cement such a narrative in such a way that it can be so easily, and legibly, deployed.

Crucial to Morrison's and Eady's intersecting use of the nonhuman is how they employ the nonhuman as a tactic to construct an oppositional gaze that reads Whiteness into hypervisibility. Miguel Rivera's essay "The Decentering of White Experience in Cornelius Eady's *Brutal Imagination*" offers an interesting reading of the "Brutal Imagination" cycle, arguing that Smith and Mr. Zero are joined through their bereavement, linked together "Just as Peter Pan staples his shadow to his feet." Rivera uses this imagery to argue that "Eady recontextualizes the tragedy and decenters Smith;" furthermore, the "sequence decenters whiteness and the white sensory experience." Instead, Mr. Zero "is the center of the narrative and the source of all existential insight offered by the sequence" as he personifies the "a previously dismal category of the white-imagined disposition of the Black American." Some of this jives with the reading presented in this article, but the idea of Whiteness being decentered does not. Rivera anchors this argument in a famous James Baldwin quote from the 1964 documentary *Take this Hammer* where Baldwin gets at the heart of the racial imaginary: "What I think of you as being is dictated by my own necessity, my own psychology, my own fears and desires … Now here in this country we've got something called the 'nigger' … I didn't invent him, White people invented him … I've always

known that I'm not a 'nigger.' But if I am not the 'nigger' and if it's true that your invention reveals you, then who is the 'nigger'?" Rivera further evidences this stance with his observation that the majority of the cycle's poems that conflate Smith and Mr. Zero imagine them housed within Mr. Zero's fictionalized Black body with the only significant deviations coming in the cycle's third section following "Press Conference" – where the reader watches as "Susan steps to the mike," but hears a "a crack in our voice" (Eady 46). In "Confession," which immediately precedes the fourth section poem "Birthing," Mr. Zero reads like a demon possessing Smith that "has almost/Spilled/From her," a phantom that " … well[s]/Under/Her eyelids" (48). These poems, instead, highlight Smith as Mr. Zero's host, struggling to keep Mr. Zero hidden, suppressing him within her as he slides "Between her teeth,/Double/Her over as she tries/Not/To blurt me out" (49).

However, we might better read the conflation of Mr. Zero and Smith through Sharpe's discussion of Black annotation and Black redaction "as trans*verse *and* coextensive ways to imagine otherwise" in the midst of the historical and ongoing ontological violence committed through the imaging and imagining of Blackness and Black bodies (115). Sharpe further describes this as working

> toward reading and seeing something in the excess of what is caught in the frame; towards seeing something beyond a visuality that is, as Nicholas Mirzoeff (2011) argues, subtended by the logics of the administered plantation. In "Home," Toni Morrison (1998, 7) writes that she has consistently tried 'to carve away the accretions of the seat, blindness, ignorance, paralysis, and share malevolence embedded in racist language so the other kinds of perception we're not only available but we're inevitable.' I am imagining that the work of Black annotation and Black redaction is to enact the movement to that inevitable—a counter to abandonment, another effort to try to look, to try to really see. (117)

Mr. Zero's presence in and position as the primary speaker of the poems is in itself an act of Black annotation, increasing the visibility of Smith's hoaxing. In this way, Mr. Zero's annotation of the Smith case and the shift of the host body of the "I" from Mr. Zero to Smith's body in the cycle's latter poems is reminiscent of John Lucas's erasure of Lawrence Beitler's 1930 photograph of a public lynching featured in Claudia Rankine's *Citizen* and Ken Gonzales-Day's "Erased Lynchings" series. Both projects take photographs of public lynchings – which were not just common, but part of a whole industry where people would pose for pictures at lynchings that were then turned into post cards that the pictured would send to their friends and loved ones – and erase the lynched bodies. These erasures highlight the White spectators, often with looks of pure glee, indifference, and other seemingly incongruent expressions, as well as, as Gonzales-Day points out, "the social conditions that made these racialized killings possible" (Anderson). Stamp Paid's "the jungle" analogy in *Beloved* presents another Morrison analog. When reflecting on the haunting taking place in 124, Stamp Paid uses the nonhuman in the form of "the jungle"

as a means to describe the racist construction of Blackness that drives White supremacy so that Stamp Paid cannot think of a Black person who "had lived a livable life" (234). While initially Stamp Paid describes "the jungle," a reference to the dehumaning of Black peoples, as something "whitefolks planted in [Black people], the focus of the metaphor turns from the Black body and focuses on how "the screaming baboon lived under their own white skin" (234). Mr. Zero's annotations have a similar rhetorical effect, redacting the Black body that Smith inserts into her hoax. At first glance, this function of Mr. Zero's annotation seems to be antithetical to Sharpe's theorization with her having defined Black annotation and redaction as "ways to make Black life visible" (123). However, what ultimately situates Eady's use of Mr. Zero within the scope of Sharpe's Black annotation and redaction, and thus also within her call to wake work, is how the intervention of Mr. Zero "disrupt[s] the dysgraphia that wrote a version of events that was riven with antiblackness" (123).

Rivera is correct to point out that these poems signal how Mr. Zero operates as a sort of phantom that elucidates the racial imaginary; however, his assessment that this decenters Smith and Whiteness, while using Baldwin to support that analysis, seems to misunderstand Baldwin and the *Why?* at the heart of Eady's persona project. Baldwin is not divesting from 'nigger' in order to decenter Whiteness. It is quite the opposite: he uses the invention to critique its inventor – Whiteness. This is a sentiment Toni Morrison later echoes while discussing the "profound neurosis" of those who subscribe to racist ideologies in a 1993 interview with Charlie Rose when she concludes that "My feeling is that white people have a very, very serious problem. And *they* should start thinking about what *they* can do about it. Take me out of it" ("Toni Morrison"; Morrison's emphasis). Mirroring Morrison's "Take me out of it" and Baldwin's divestment, the shift of the "I" being housed in the fictionalized Black body to the real White body exhibits how Eady is, through Black annotation and redaction, centering Whiteness through an oppositional gaze that illuminates that it is Whiteness that found it necessary to invent Mr. Zero and that continues to maintain his job security. As a metaphorical representation of Eady's *Why?*, and as a product of the "brutal imagination," Mr. Zero may appear Black, but he is born of and from Whiteness. His work, as Eady re-deploys him, is not to push aside Whiteness, but to render it hypervisible.[8]

[8]GerShun Avilez presents a similar argument in the first chapter of his book *Radical Aesthetics and Modern Black Nationalism* (2016) where he states that: "What Eady actually presents in his work is his own imagining of this White figure imagining a black figure; he inhabits this White persona that is involved in the veritable creation of Black identity. The poetic cycle is as much about conceptions of Whiteness as it is about conceptions of Blackness" (54). He reads Smith's conjuring of Mr. Zero as an "instance of catachrestic misnaming [that] illustrates how Whiteness performs itself as Blackness" (56). As such, Eady's imagining of Smith summoning Mr. Zero effectively illustrates how Whiteness "makes itself invisible to ensure its presence. In enabling Susan's innocence, the phantasmatic Zero represents the conceptual manifestation of both the rhetoric of [White] innocence and Black abstraction" (56).

The palatable Blackness of the plausible victim

Many of the poems in Eady's cycle center on Mr. Zero as plausible villain. The cycle then illuminates, through poems like "How I Got Born" and "Charles Stuart in the Hospital," how Mr. Zero is signifyin' on the legacy of racial hoaxers and their exploitation of Mr. Zero's labor.[9] Yet, what isn't always on the surface of the poems is that every time Mr. Zero is called to work, there is a ripple effect sent through the Black communities in close proximity to his job site – both geographically and socially. Consequently, the plausible victim exists, and persists, in a causal relationship with the plausible villain, the victimization of Black peoples being a byproduct of racist ideas and actions that reify or capitalize on the belief that Black peoples are genetically and/or culturally less good, less citizen, less human.[10] The intertwined histories of the racial hoax and the plausible Black victim runs at least as far back as the Redemption Era and its climate of racial terror, if not located in the origins of the Transatlantic slave trade. Instances of racialized violence as a result of a racial hoax were, and are, still very present – particularly when we consider the racial hoax's responsibility in bolstering the myth of the *criminalblackman* and how that, in turn, has played a direct role in the current weather of police violence and terror against Black folks. The Charles Stuart case referenced in "Charles Stuart in the Hospital" serves as a prime example with Stuart's racial hoax leading to, and enabling, the Boston Police Department (BPD) to produce one of the first large-scale abuses of the stop-and-frisk policy, incarcerating two Black men and committing over 150 stop-and-frisks per day between October 24th and October 28th, 1989 with similar levels of searches occurring through November 1989 (Naughton). The emotional and psychological trauma of such a climate is difficult to quantify as it hardly ever stays put; it tends to haunt through its ripples, its echoes, its repetition.[11]

The state-sanctioned terror and humiliation brought on by, and that seeks justification in, the racial hoax speaks to another form of ontological violence. Instead of the ontological violence committed through the racist framing of the *criminalblackman*, this ontological violence proffers emotional

[9]Henry Louis Gates Jr. theorizes signifyin' in *The Signifying Monkey: A Theory of African-American Literary Criticism* as, "Whatever is black about black American literature is to be found in this identifiable black Signifyin(g) difference" (xxiv). Subsumed within signifyin' are several rhetorical tropes, including metaphor, synecdoche, metonymy, irony, and others, justifying Gates's characterization of signifyin' as the "black trope of all tropes, trope of tropes, the figure of figures." Signifyin', in its simplest definition, is "repetition and revision, or repetition with a signal difference" (xxiv).

[10]We might meditate here on the dominant culture's propensity for digging into Black victims' pasts and critiquing the victim's appearance and/or degree of compliance to explain away police brutality, lynchings, and other racist policing practices.

[11]In an interview Boston community advocate Frederick Johnson gave to the *Washington Post* 30 years after the Stuart case, he recalled a particularly egregious night when he witnessed: "A group of at least 30 African American men, young to middle aged, were lying on the ground, stripped naked, their arms handcuffed behind their backs." Johnson likened this scene to "how [slave traffickers] shackled slaves into ship galleys, one on top of the other," adding "They were treated like animals" (Bernard).

and psychological trauma that constitutes "another assault on the souls and honor of black folks" (Bernard). This ontological violence is also situated in abjection and Black non/Being; in the dehumaning in the preamble, present, and wake of racialized violence and oppression, in this spectacle of Black suffering. This abjection accommodates the complacency and complicity needed for White supremacy and racial capitalism to thrive comfortably on a steady fuel of Black pain. This violence is manifest in Mr. Zero's name. Mr. Zero operates as a nameless, amorphic entity throughout much of the cycle; he is named only in the title of "The Unsigned Confession of Mr. Zero" (35). The name signifies Black non/Being in a direct way, Zero citing the value that Smith and her fellow racial hoaxers place on the Black lives of their plausible victims and their real and attempted social murders.[12] Eady's naming can be further read as an ironic riff on Odysseus's "My name is Nobody" (Homer). Yet, whereas Odysseus's trickery is the means by which some of his men and he escape the cyclops Polyphemus, the signifyin' in Mr. Zero's name is another means by which Eady exposes what had appeared to be a Black body was in actuality the monstrous shadow of – or, as Stamp Paid, put it, "the jungle" undergirding – the racial imaginary. Like Odysseus's, Eady's naming also orchestrates a sort of escape, yet through this naming, Eady is also enacting Black annotation and redaction as a means to blast what Sharpe calls the "dysgraphia and orthography of the wake" (115): his name correcting the racist narrative by underscoring his nonpresence as well as highlighting the layers of violence that result from its blatant disregard for Black lives. As such the "Brutal Imagination" cycle's Black redaction subverts the racist annotation of Black bodies by figuratively snatching the Black out Smith's mouth.[13]

Eady drives home this strategy in the direct Black annotation in "Birthing." As the final poem of the cycle, "Birthing" joins "How I Got Born" not only as the cycle's bookends, but "Birthing" also offers an interesting return to Mr. Zero's origins (at least within the Smith episode): similar to the Gospels, the poems provide two takes on this particular nativity scene. Not to belabor this parallel, but it is interesting to consider how Smith reaches to find a more devious sense of salvation through her evocation of Mr. Zero's image as well as her appeal for grace that very often is on the ready when a White woman's tears are spilled. Through first merging Smith with Mr. Zero in "How I Got Born," Eady's pronoun use linguistically signals that the Black man Smith claimed to have stolen her car and her children is in actuality part of Smith's racial imagination,

[12]Toward this end, GerShun Avilez connects Mr. Zero's name to the concept of "zero image" that Black Arts era Carolyn Gerald theorizes in her 1976 essay, "The Black Writer and His Role." Gerald's "zero image" is very similar to Russell-Brown's *criminalblackman* in how it denotes the racialized pathologized images of Blackness that White cultural producers project into the public sphere. Through this framing, Avilez notes that "The name Zero suggests the lack of identity and a reduced, abstracted existence" (55).

[13]Though I do not address this in the text of this article, it may be worth considering Eady's riff on Greek mythology along with Morrison's noted interest in, and frequent allusions to, the Classics.

occupying her space though in an imagined Black body. Eady's immediate observation that Smith is not the first to put Mr. Zero to work concurrently places Smith in a cultural and historical context and frames her as an individual representative of a larger whole – White supremacy – with her "brutal imagination" finding its genesis in the racial imaginary. This is further evidenced by Eady's inclusion of other figures like Aunt Jemima, Uncles Ben and Tom, Buckwheat, and Stepin Fetchit in the cycle's second section and his placement of the myth of the *criminalblackman* on the same plane as these other antiBlack caricatures. In doing so, Eady is able to draw into sharper focus the social conditions that invent and employ Mr. Zero as well as mammies, uncles, and dancing Sambos. This (dis)articulation sets up the spatial and grammatical separation in "Birthing."

The title – "Birthing" – establishes the poem's irony, signaling early its signifyin' potential. The term "birthing" brings to mind birthing people and motherhood and serves as a reminder of Smith's status as a birthing person and, simultaneously, her betrayal of her motherhood, particularly with the poem reading her confession as being more concerned with her own mental and emotional state than the safety and well-being of her children. T he title also echoes the title of the first poem of the cycle, "How I Got Born," and like "How I got Born" implies that the poem will provide Mr. Zero's birth story, which they both do but with their own slant: whereas "How I Got Born" askews the notion of birth to describe how Smith conjures Mr. Zero, calls him to work, "Birthing" plays on yet another meaning for "birth": extraction. In this way, the title foregrounds Mr. Zero's removal of himself from the picture through Eady's use of Black annotation and redaction in the poem, and in the "Brutal Imagination" cycle more broadly. In this way, the title, establishes how "Birthing" drives home the cycle's (dis)articulation of Smith's hoax, through pointing out her individual racism. Additionally, and more notably, the title also seizes on the kairotic moment Smith's racist hoaxing creates in order to (counter-)employ her as a synecdoche for the more pernicious systemic racism that serves as the arbiter of the social death that emanates from the curation and exploitation of a Blackness the dominant culture finds palatable due its proximity to physical and/or social death. What is brought forward, then, in "Birthing" is not Mr. Zero's Black body, but Smith's, as well as the dominant culture's, toxic Whiteness (itself bordering on, if not transgressing into, the pathological).

In the body of the poem itself, Mr. Zero annotates excerpts from Smith's hand-written confession. As such, he speaks himself into nonexistence. The call-and-response structure that annotates Smith's confession with Mr. Zero's signifyin' back talk makes Eady's/Mr. Zero's annotation of Smith all the more visible, assigning their words different space and as well as a different typeface – with the excerpts from Smith's confession appearing in italics. Whereas before the pronoun usage typically conflated Mr. Zero and Smith

(typically within the same physical or imagined body), Eady disentangles the two when returning to the recollection of the night of Smith's filicide – paralleling the first three stanzas of "How I Got Born" – though this time through Smith's perspective via her confession. Though it would seem that these visual cues would work to make Mr. Zero's presence more readily apparent, Mr. Zero's annotations foreground his absence. Before the poem's final two lines, much of the descriptors used to describe Mr. Zero are there to remind the reader what he is not and where he is not. In the six couplets spoken through Mr. Zero in the first section of "Birthing," there are five negations, four alone in the final two couplets, which read:

> At this point, I have no language,
> No tongue, no mouth.
>
> I am not me, yet.
> I am just an understanding. (53)

Of the nine sections that follow, five include at least one negation that result a similar trend that highlights Mr. Zero's physical nonexistence. The negations in Mr. Zero again bring to mind lynching erasure artwork and how the redaction of the Black body draws Whiteness into sharp(er) focus. This structure – using annotation to redact – enhances the poem's irony and, thus, its ability draw our eye to Smith and how she metonymically represents the systemic forces that sustain racial hoaxes. It is at this point, the focus on this particular disappearance, that the poem's irony is best revealed. The mind might be tempted to jump to Smith's inconsistencies, narcissism, and White tears. It is tempting to focus on how Smith seems to describe how things happened suddenly and juxtapose that with how a reenactment showed that it likely took six minutes for her car to submerge. It is tempting to get in the weeds around how some studies show that high stress situations impact one's perception of time. Yet, that is not what Eady is doing here. Instead, he is redacting the presence of a Black body, while highlighting Smith's White body. He is lingering in the space in between her confession statements, not as places of Black aspiration – in fact Mr. Zero has yet to breathe – but as a site for executing the extraction of the Black body from Smith's letter – highlighting the absence of Blackness – while alluding to its fixation in her imagination; it being so fixed, or conditioned, there that even under extreme duress and stress and all that Smith describes, she was able to understand and exploit the racist logic that people would most readily accept her story if she hangs it on a Black body.

This trajectory – from merging Mr. Zero with Smith to then pointing out Mr. Zero's lack of physical existence – is made especially effective, if not possible, through the irony created by Eady's use of nonhuman personae as

a commentary on Black non/being. In doing so, Eady is able to play on Mr. Zero's literal lack of being, while critically reading the ontological violence inherent in Smith's racial hoax that was able to persist not because of the airtightness of Smith's lie, but due to the dominant culture's familiar relationship with and committed investment in the myth of the *criminal-blackman*. As a result of its redaction of the Black body from this equation and annotation of its utter Whiteness, this reading renders toxic Whiteness and its creation of and fixation on Blackness made palatable by its relation to physical and/or social death visible and legible. Morrison has made clear that her aim is to center Black peoples, and, in doing so, she often offered an oppositional gaze, even while refusing to privilege Whiteness. While there are plenty of places where we might see Morrison's influence, her wake, broadly within U.S. American literature as well as more locally within the 21st-century brand of Black U.S. American persona poetry and its engagement with dominant narratives, this is where Morrison shows through the most in this particular work: in Eady's effective utilization of her model for employing the nonhuman to do decolonizing (wake) work. It is through employing Morrison's tactics that the "Brutal Imagination" cycle is able to write off the racist stamp from the Black body and reassign it to the racist itself, placing the pathology where it actually exists, in the dominant culture's perpetuation of, dependence on, and investment in racist U.S. institutions and structures and not in particular minoritized communities.

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